

Module 06: Relationships and Communication

MISSION REBUILD™ | 12-Week Veteran Transition Course

Week 6 of 12

Module Overview

Here's something nobody tells you at the out-processing briefing: the military doesn't just change what you know or what you can do. It rewires *how you connect with other people*.

You spent years — maybe decades — inside a system that valued directness, hierarchy, shared mission, and a very particular kind of trust. The guy to your left and right knew what you knew. He'd been through the same grinder. You didn't have to explain yourself. You didn't have to manage feelings. You showed up, you did the work, you had each other's backs. That was the relationship.

Civilian life doesn't work that way.

Out here, people communicate in circles. They hint instead of direct. They need context you assume everyone has. They get offended by bluntness that would've been totally normal at 0500 formation. Your spouse wants to *talk about feelings*. Your new coworkers seem fragile. Your old civilian friends have moved on and you don't know where you fit. And underneath all of it, you're navigating something most of them will never understand: the weight of what you carried.

This module is not about becoming someone you're not. It's not about softening your edges to fit into a world that doesn't deserve you as-is. It's about understanding what changed — in you and in your communication — so you can operate effectively *as yourself* in civilian relationships without leaving a trail of burned bridges, isolated family members, and missed connections behind you.

You've adapted to harder things than this. This is learnable. Let's get into it.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will be able to:

1. Identify specific ways military service shaped your communication patterns, relational expectations, and emotional expression — and articulate which of those serve you and which cost you.
 2. Apply practical strategies for building genuine civilian friendships and community without forcing it or faking compatibility.
 3. Navigate romantic and family relationships with greater self-awareness, including communication patterns around emotional availability, conflict, and reintegration.
 4. Demonstrate emotional intelligence as a tactical skill — reading situations accurately, managing your reactions under pressure, and expressing needs directly without emotional shutdown or blowup.
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Lesson 1: How Military Service Changed the Way You Relate

The Command-and-Control Default

You were trained in a communication model that is extraordinarily effective — in the right context. Clear orders. Defined roles. Minimal ambiguity. You say it once. People execute. Accountability is real and immediate. There's no committee meeting to discuss whether the mission should happen. Hierarchy exists for a reason and everyone respects it.

That model worked because the environment demanded it. Stakes were high. Speed mattered. Clarity wasn't a preference — it was survival.

Then you left.

Now you're in a world where nobody has a rank, nobody is going to follow a direct order, consensus is a cultural expectation, and people actually want to be *asked*, not told. Your coworkers want to be involved in the decision. Your spouse wants to feel like a partner, not a subordinate. Your kids don't respond to commands the way junior enlisted did. And your natural impulse — because it's been trained into you at a cellular level — is to cut through the noise, make the call, and move.

That impulse isn't wrong. It's just mismatched to the context.

Command-and-control communication in civilian contexts looks like:

- Cutting off discussion because you've already decided
- Delivering feedback as critique without diplomatic framing
- Assuming compliance and being genuinely confused when people push back
- Skipping the "why" because where you came from, the "why" was above your pay grade or irrelevant
- Being impatient with emotional content in conversations

- Treating questions as challenges to your authority

Civilians read this as arrogance, coldness, or aggression. They're not wrong that something is off — they're just misreading the source.

The Hyper-Independence Trap

Military culture simultaneously breeds profound unit cohesion *and* a kind of emotional self-sufficiency that can make real intimacy almost impossible. You were rewarded for not needing anything. Stoicism was functional. Asking for help was for weak links. You handled your business and you didn't put your problems on your team.

That works inside a military unit. In a marriage, a friendship, or a family, it reads as walls. It reads as "I don't need you." And over time, the people who want to be close to you stop trying — because trying to get through to someone who's sealed off is exhausting.

Hyper-independence after service looks like:

- Refusing help even when you clearly need it
- Not telling your spouse what's wrong because "it's fine" and "I'll handle it"
- Ghosting friendships when life gets hard rather than leaning in
- Solving every problem solo and feeling vaguely resentful that nobody stepped up
- An inability to be vulnerable even in safe, private relationships
- Making decisions that affect your family unilaterally, then being confused why they're frustrated

What This Costs You

This isn't just about being more relatable. The research on social connection is unambiguous: isolation is physically dangerous. Veterans die — by suicide, by substance, by slow deterioration — at rates that trace directly back to disconnection. The mission-less, brother-less, purposeless civilian experience is genuinely lethal for some men.

The way you communicate and relate is downstream of whether you build a life that's actually worth living after service. This isn't soft. This is operational.

The Adaptation Frame

Here's the reframe that matters: adapting your communication style for civilian life is not capitulation. It's not weakness. It's the same thing you did every time you operated in a new environment — you read the terrain, adjusted your approach, and executed the mission.

You're still you. The values don't change. The standards don't drop. You just learn when to use which tool.

Lesson 2: Rebuilding Civilian Friendships

Why Military Friendships Hit Different

You already know this, but let's name it clearly: military friendships are forged under conditions that civilian friendships almost never replicate. Shared hardship. Life-or-death stakes. No exit. No pretense. You can't fake who you are when you're running on four hours of sleep and everything hurts and the mission is still on.

That kind of bond doesn't require maintenance. You can call someone you served with after five years and pick up mid-sentence. You don't have to explain yourself because they *were there*. And the loyalty runs deeper than most civilians will ever experience in a friendship.

When you leave service, you lose the mechanism that created those friendships. And nothing on the civilian side replicates it automatically. So what happens?

You find yourself surrounded by people who seem fine — friendly, decent, well-meaning — and you feel completely alone. Not because there's something wrong with them. Not because you're broken. But because the type of friendship you're looking for requires conditions that don't exist in normal civilian life unless you deliberately create them.

The Mistake Most Veterans Make

The most common pattern: veterans stop trying.

They chalk it up to "civilians don't get it," maintain their military friendships remotely (which is good, but not sufficient), and gradually become more isolated. They tell themselves they're fine because they have their spouse or their gym or their work. But the data on male friendship — especially male friendship after 30 — shows that isolated men deteriorate. Cognitively. Emotionally. Physically.

You need people. Not therapy-speak people. Not drinking-buddy people. Real people who know who you are, challenge you, and have your back. Building that after service is one of the harder interpersonal tasks you'll face.

Where Real Community Actually Forms

You will not find your people at networking events. You will not find them at a generic veterans social mixer where everyone wears their branch on their sleeve and talks about their old unit. Those events can be a starting point, but they're not the destination.

Real community forms around shared activity with repeated exposure over time. That's the formula. Period.

Where to apply it:

- **Training environments.** A serious gym, a BJJ or boxing gym, a competitive sports team. Hard physical activity with other people creates the closest civilian approximation to unit cohesion. People who suffer together bond. Find a place where the standard is high and the people are consistent.
- **Skill-based groups.** Hunting clubs. Off-road wheeling groups. Shooting sports leagues. Woodworking guilds. Anything where people show up regularly, have high standards for what they're doing, and where the activity itself is the focus — not the socializing. The friendship is the byproduct, not the goal.
- **Mission-adjacent organizations.** Team Red White & Blue. The Mission Continues. Pat Tillman Foundation. Organizations that give you a peer group and a mission simultaneously are underrated.
- **Building something.** If you're starting a business, a project, or a community effort, you'll naturally attract people who are serious. Working toward something with people is one of the oldest friendship-forming mechanisms that exists.

How to Actually Build It

Civilian friendship requires what military friendship never did: initiation, patience, and maintenance. You have to take the first step. You have to follow up. You have to invest before you feel the return.

This feels weird for veterans. You're used to relationships that exist because the structure puts you together. In civilian life, you have to deliberately build the structure yourself.

Practical steps:

1. **Identify your interest categories and find the serious version.** Not the casual version — the version where people actually care and show up consistently.
2. **Show up repeatedly before it feels like it's working.** Community takes months, not weeks. You're planting seeds.
3. **Initiate directly.** Ask someone to train together. Invite them to a specific event. Civilians respect directness when it's not aggressive — most of them are waiting for someone to just make a plan.
4. **Be useful.** Veterans often have skills, reliability, and follow-through that civilians don't. Show those things in action. Trust is built by watching someone perform over time.
5. **Accept that depth takes time.** You won't recreate a combat-forged bond in six months. But you can build genuine, meaningful friendship over a year or two of consistent showing up.

Lesson 3: Romantic Relationships After Service

What Service Did to Your Relationship Patterns

Military service affects intimate relationships in ways most veterans don't fully map until they're in the middle of a blown-up marriage or a string of failed relationships. Let's be direct about what actually happens.

Emotional compartmentalization. You learned to put your feelings in a box and close the lid. That skill kept you functional in high-stress operational environments. In a romantic relationship, it reads as emotional unavailability, shutdown during conflict, and a partner who can never really get close to you.

Conflict avoidance or conflict escalation. Veterans often swing to one extreme or the other. Either they avoid emotional conflict entirely (because conflict where you're from had real consequences and emotional arguments seemed beneath the threshold of "real" problems), or they escalate quickly and intensely when they feel threatened or disrespected.

Mission-mode over relationship-mode. You're wired to be productive, to fix problems, to execute. Your partner comes to you with an emotional issue and your brain immediately goes to: *What's the solution? What's the action item? Let's fix this and move forward.* But often they don't want a solution. They want to be heard. And you sitting there generating action items while they're trying to connect makes them feel alone.

Trust deficits from service. If your relationship survived deployment or long separations, you both adapted — and not always in ways that translate cleanly to being together full-time. Spouses who managed everything while you were gone built systems that don't include you. Veterans who bonded deeply with their unit sometimes find their civilian partner feels like a stranger.

Post-service identity drift. Your partner fell for the version of you that existed in uniform. You're different now. Maybe they don't know how to relate to who you're becoming. Maybe you don't either. This is normal and navigable — but it requires honest conversation, not avoidance.

For Veterans Who Are Single

Dating as a veteran in the civilian world involves a few specific landmines.

The over-selection problem: Your standards aren't the issue. Having standards is right. The issue is applying military selection criteria to civilian people who aren't competing for a slot. Civilians don't have to prove themselves to you. People who seem "soft" or "unserious" by your metric might just be living differently, not worse.

The under-communication problem: You assume people can read intent. They can't. Civilian dating culture is already a minefield of ambiguity; add a veteran who doesn't signal emotionally and you're going

to confuse a lot of people who might have been great partners.

The vulnerability gap: Intimacy requires showing someone who you actually are, including the parts that aren't operationally clean. If every answer to "how are you doing?" is "fine" or "good," and every discussion of your service is a carefully edited highlight reel, you're not actually letting anyone in. That catches up with you.

Communication Patterns That Create Connection

This is the core skill: most relationship problems between veterans and their partners come down to communication gaps that neither person fully understands.

Learn to make bids for connection. Research by Dr. John Gottman (and yes, this is tactical, not therapy-fluff) shows that relationships live or die by what he calls "bids" — small attempts to connect, get attention, or share a moment. Your partner says "look at this sunset." You grunt without looking up. That's a missed bid. Over thousands of missed bids, the emotional bank account goes to zero.

Say the direct thing. You're good at direct communication in tactical contexts. Apply it to your relationship. "I'm struggling with the transition and I'm not sure how to talk about it yet, but I want you to know it's not about us." That kind of direct honesty — even when it's not fully resolved — builds more trust than silence.

Understand the difference between venting and problem-solving. Ask your partner: "Do you want me to listen or do you want me to help?" This one question eliminates a massive percentage of communication friction.

Don't weaponize your service. "You have no idea what I've been through" is sometimes true and always a conversation stopper. Your partner doesn't need to have been downrange to deserve respect and to have legitimate grievances. Don't make your service a trump card that ends hard conversations.

Lesson 4: Family Dynamics and Communication

The Reintegration Problem That Doesn't End

Reintegration isn't just a thing that happens after deployment. For many veterans, *getting out* is the biggest reintegration of all — and it's the one with the least institutional support.

You come home permanently. And home has changed. Your kids got older. Your parents have opinions about what you should do next. Your spouse built a life that runs without you. The family system evolved in your absence, and now you're back full-time — and you don't quite fit where you used to.

The natural response for a lot of veterans is to try to reassert their old role. To come back in strong, make the calls, establish the routine. But the family system doesn't have a slot for that anymore. They adapted. And your attempt to plug back into the old configuration creates friction.

This isn't a failure of your family. It's a systems problem.

With Spouses and Partners

If your partner held things together while you served, they earned something. They made decisions, handled crises, raised kids, managed finances — and they developed competence and confidence in doing it. When you come back and want to take over, what they hear is: "I don't trust what you built." That's not what you mean. But it's what lands.

The move is not to subordinate yourself. It's to *reintegrate* — which means coming in as a partner, not a commander. Ask what they need. Ask where you can help. Build back the shared responsibility gradually. And be honest when you feel like an outsider in your own home — because that feeling is real and common and doesn't mean you failed.

Also: if the relationship survived your service years, that partnership is worth fighting for. Most of what erodes veteran marriages isn't catastrophic — it's the slow drift of two people who stopped really talking. Fix that first.

With Kids

Your kids relate to you based on who you were when you were present. If you were gone for years, they have a version of you in their head that's partly real and partly constructed. You come back and you're a different person than that construction — and that's disorienting for them.

Younger kids need consistency and physical presence. They rebuild trust by watching you show up reliably over time. You can't compress that.

Older kids — especially teenagers — may have a relationship with you that's frozen at whatever age they were when you left. They may be angry. They may have tested their mom or dad in your absence and built a whole identity you weren't around for. You can't parent them like they're still seven.

The move with kids of any age: get curious. Don't come home as the authority figure who sets the tone. Come home as someone who wants to know who they are now. Ask questions. Be interested. The authority will come back naturally as they trust you — but trust you have to earn again.

With Parents

Your parents have their own version of who you are — probably the version before you left. They may have ideas about what you should do next (get a safe job, settle down, go back to school) that feel completely disconnected from your reality.

Veterans often find that family of origin conversations feel infantilizing. You've made life-and-death decisions. You've led people. And you come home and your mother is asking if you're eating enough. That's maddening — and also, she's your mother and she loves you and she doesn't have another mode.

The move here: be patient with the gap and direct about boundaries. "Mom, I appreciate that you're worried. I need you to trust that I'm figuring it out." You don't have to explain yourself in full. But dismissing or avoiding family members who care about you creates distance that calcifies.

Setting Boundaries That Actually Work

A boundary isn't a wall. It's a clear statement of what you will and won't accept, delivered calmly and enforced consistently.

The veteran version of "setting a boundary" too often looks like either total silence (hoping people will figure it out) or an explosion when you've finally had enough. Neither works.

Functional boundary communication: "When you [specific behavior], I feel [honest impact], and I need [specific ask]." This is not therapy-speak — it's a mission brief. Clear problem, clear consequence, clear solution.

Lesson 5: Emotional Intelligence as a Veteran Skill

Reframe: EQ Is a Tactical Capability

Let's dispense with the idea that emotional intelligence is soft. The operators who are best at their jobs — the ones who can debrief a team after a hard mission, navigate a foreign partner force, read an ambiguous situation and make the right call — are emotionally intelligent. They read people accurately. They manage their own state under pressure. They know when to push and when to pull back. They communicate with precision.

Emotional intelligence isn't about being in touch with your feelings. It's about information processing. Emotional data is real data. The veteran who can read a room — who knows when the family is at a breaking point, when a coworker is about to quit, when a negotiation is going sideways — has a significant tactical advantage.

Reading the Room

Military training gives you hyperawareness of physical threat cues. Civilians don't broadcast the same way — or rather, they broadcast differently. Learning to read civilian emotional environments requires recalibration.

What to watch for:

- Body language clusters, not isolated signals. Someone crossing their arms and leaning back with no eye contact is not cold — they're probably guarded. Ask why.
- Tone changes. When someone who normally speaks fluidly starts choosing words carefully, something is off. Pay attention.
- What's *not* being said. Civilians often communicate disagreement or discomfort by going quiet, deflecting, or changing the subject. Silence is data.
- Energy shifts in a group. If a conversation was flowing and it suddenly gets stilted, something hit a nerve. Note it.

Managing Your Own Reactions

Veterans can be triggered in civilian contexts by things that seem trivial — a raised voice, a perceived slight, someone questioning your judgment. The physiological response is real: your nervous system doesn't distinguish between a minor interpersonal confrontation and a threat. Same activation, different context.

The tactical skill is the *pause*. Not repression. Not explosion. The deliberate pause between stimulus and response.

In practice: when you feel the activation — the heat in your chest, the jaw tightening, the urge to cut through the noise — that's your signal to slow down, not speed up. Take a breath. Give yourself three seconds. Ask yourself: "What is actually happening here, and what response serves the outcome I want?"

This is the difference between reacting and responding. You already know this from combat — don't rush the shot if you're not sure of the target. Apply it in civilian interactions.

Expressing Needs Directly

This is the one most veterans struggle with most. Expressing a need feels like admitting a weakness. It runs counter to every instinct that got you through service.

But here's the reality: unexpressed needs become resentment. Resentment becomes distance. Distance becomes the end of relationships and the end of teams.

Expressing a need directly is not weakness. It's mature, it's efficient, and it respects the other person enough to tell them the truth.

Direct expression of need doesn't mean: *I need to talk about my feelings and process my emotional experience*. It can mean: "I need you to give me 20 minutes when I get home before we get into anything. I need to decompress first." That's a need. It's direct. It's actionable. Your partner can work with that.

Active Listening as a Veteran Adaptation

Active listening is a force multiplier in civilian relationships. Most people — especially in emotionally charged conversations — are waiting to respond, not actually listening. The person who is genuinely listening has enormous advantage and builds disproportionate trust.

Active listening means:

- Full attention. Phone down. Eye contact. Body oriented toward the person.
- Reflective responses. "What I'm hearing is [paraphrase]. Is that right?" This is not weakness — this is the same verification loop you'd use to confirm orders.
- Tolerating silence. Let people finish. Resist the impulse to fix, redirect, or counter while they're still talking.
- Asking one good question instead of talking. "What do you need from me right now?" is one of the highest-leverage sentences in any relationship.

Examples from Veteran Transition

Mike, Army Infantry, 12 years: After his ETS, Mike's wife told him she felt like she was living with a stranger. He was home physically but completely checked out emotionally. He'd answer questions with one syllable and retreat to the garage. It wasn't malice — it was the only mode he had. He started deliberately sitting at the dinner table for twenty minutes after he ate and asking his kids one question about their day. Not fixing anything. Just being present. Six months later, his wife said she finally felt like he was back.

Darius, Marine Corps Logistics, 8 years: Darius found civilian friendships hollow at first and stopped trying. He missed his unit and everyone else seemed shallow by comparison. He started training at a serious CrossFit gym and slowly built relationships around the shared suffering of hard workouts. Two years out, he has three people he'd call in a real crisis — two veterans, one civilian. He considers that a success.

James, Navy EOD, 10 years: James's dating life after separation was a series of short relationships where women described him as "closed off" and "hard to read." He started working on one specific thing:

telling people what was actually going on in his head instead of defaulting to "I'm good." Not emotional processing — just accurate reporting. "Actually, I've been stressed about the job search." That level of honesty, which felt huge to him, was the minimum that allowed real connection to happen.

Practical Exercises

Exercise 1: The Communication Style Audit

Over the next seven days, keep a running log of significant conversations. For each one, note:

- What you said vs. what you intended to communicate
- How the other person responded
- Whether there was a gap between your intent and their reception
- What a different approach might have looked like

At the end of the week, look for patterns. Where does your military communication style create friction? Where does it actually work well?

Exercise 2: The Bid for Connection Challenge

For two weeks, make a deliberate bid for connection once per day with someone in your life. Not a grand gesture — a small, intentional moment. Ask a genuine question. Compliment something specific. Acknowledge something they did. Notice who responds and how.

Exercise 3: The Needs Inventory

Write down three things you need from each important relationship in your life (partner, parent, friend, colleague). Now answer honestly: Have you communicated these needs directly? If not, what's stopping you? Write one direct, clear needs statement for each relationship and decide whether and how to deliver it.

Exercise 4: The Active Listening Drill

In your next five conversations where the other person is sharing something personal, practice full active listening. No phone. No mental response-drafting. When they finish, reflect back what you heard before responding with your own content. Track whether the conversation quality changes.

Reflection Prompts

1. Think about the closest friendship you had in service. What made it real? What conditions created it? Are those conditions replicable in your civilian life in some form?
 2. In what ways has your communication style created friction in your most important relationships since leaving service? Be specific — not "I'm bad at talking" but what specific patterns, what specific moments?
 3. When was the last time you expressed a genuine emotional need to someone in your life? What happened? What does your pattern of expressing (or not expressing) needs cost you?
 4. How has your family changed while you were in? How have *you* changed? Where is the disconnect between who they think you are and who you actually are now?
 5. What is one relationship in your life that you have let drift because of your communication patterns? What would it take to rebuild it?
 6. When you feel activated or reactive in a conversation, what does that feel like physically? What is your current default response? What would a better response look like?
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Discussion Prompts

1. **The friendship gap:** Veterans often describe civilian friendships as shallow compared to the bonds formed in service. Do you agree? What is it about military friendships that civilian life makes hard to replicate — and is that gap bridgeable? Share where you're at with building community post-service.
 2. **The family reintegration reality:** Permanent separation from service may be the biggest reintegration most veterans experience. Share one specific challenge you've faced — or are facing — in reintegrating with your family. What's working? What isn't?
 3. **Emotional expression and masculinity:** Military culture is explicit about strength and stoicism. But this module argues that expressing needs and being emotionally available is itself a form of strength. Where do you draw that line for yourself? What does healthy emotional expression look like in your life, specifically?
 4. **The relationship that almost didn't make it:** Many veterans nearly lost — or did lose — a key relationship during or after service. If you're willing to share, what was the breaking point, and what did or didn't allow repair?
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Quiz Questions

1. What is "command-and-control communication" and why does it create problems in civilian relationships?

Answer: Command-and-control communication is a direct, hierarchical, minimal-explanation style effective in military environments. In civilian relationships, it reads as arrogance, dismissiveness, or emotional coldness because civilian culture expects collaboration, explanation, and emotional attunement.

2. What does hyper-independence look like in a romantic relationship, and what does it cost?

Answer: It looks like refusing help, not communicating problems, making unilateral decisions, and maintaining emotional distance. It costs intimacy, trust, and partnership because it signals to the other person that they're not needed or trusted.

3. According to the module, what is the formula for real community formation?

Answer: Shared activity + repeated exposure + time. Real community is built around doing something meaningful together, consistently, over an extended period — not around social events or intentional networking.

4. What is a "bid for connection" and why does it matter in relationships?

Answer: A bid is a small attempt to connect, share, or get attention. Research shows that how partners respond to bids — turning toward or away — is one of the strongest predictors of relationship health. Consistently missing bids erodes the relationship over time.

5. Why do veterans often experience difficulty with romantic emotional availability?

Answer: Military training explicitly rewards emotional compartmentalization, stoicism, and self-sufficiency. These adaptations, which are functional in service, translate to shutdown, walls, and disconnection in intimate relationships where vulnerability is required for real closeness.

6. What is the recommended approach when reintegrating into a family system that has adapted without you?

Answer: Come in as a partner and collaborator, not a commander. Acknowledge what your family built in your absence, ask where you can contribute, and rebuild trust and shared responsibility gradually rather than trying to reclaim control.

7. How is emotional intelligence defined in this module, and why is it considered tactical rather than soft?

Answer: EQ is defined as information processing — using emotional data (reading people, reading rooms, managing your own state) to make better decisions and operate more effectively. The best operators are emotionally intelligent. It's a tactical capability, not a personality trait.

8. What is the tactical purpose of the "pause" when you feel activated in a conflict?

Answer: The pause creates a gap between stimulus and response, allowing you to choose your response deliberately rather than reacting automatically. It's the civilian equivalent of "don't rush the shot" — slowing down to get the right outcome.

9. What does the module say is the consequence of unexpressed needs in relationships?

Answer: Unexpressed needs become resentment, resentment becomes distance, and distance ends relationships. Expressing needs directly is efficient, respectful, and mature — not a sign of weakness.

10. What are the four elements of active listening described in this module?

Answer: Full attention (phone down, eye contact, body oriented toward the speaker), reflective responses (paraphrasing to verify), tolerating silence (letting the person finish), and asking one good question ("What do you need from me right now?") rather than immediately offering your own content.

Module Assignment: Relationship Audit and Communication Goals Document

Objective: Complete a structured inventory of your key relationships and build a concrete communication improvement plan.

Deliverable: A 1,000–1,500 word document with the following sections:

Part 1: Relationship Audit (500 words)

Map out your five most important current relationships (partner, parent, sibling, friend, coworker — whatever applies). For each, answer:

- What is the current health of this relationship (honest assessment, 1–10)?
- What role does your communication style play in any friction?
- What does this person need from you that you're not currently providing?
- What do you need from them that you haven't communicated?

Part 2: Communication Pattern Assessment (300 words)

Answer these questions honestly:

- Which elements of command-and-control communication show up in your relationships?
- Where does hyper-independence cost you connection?
- What is your default under emotional stress — shutdown, escalation, or something else?
- What is one thing you do well relationally that you should do more of?

Part 3: 90-Day Communication Goals (300 words)

Write three specific, behavioral goals for the next 90 days. Not vague intentions ("be more open") — specific behaviors ("tell my partner once per week something that's actually on my mind before they have to ask"). Include:

- Who the goal is with
- What the specific behavior is
- How you'll know it's working
- What accountability structure you'll use

Downloadable Worksheet: Relationship and Communication Toolkit

Section A: Relationship Inventory

For each relationship, complete the following fields:

| Field | Person 1 | Person 2 | Person 3 | Person 4 | Person 5 |

|---|---|---|---|---|

| Name/Role | | | | |

| Current health (1–10) | | | | |

| Last meaningful conversation (when?) | | | | |

| Main communication friction | | | | |

| What they need from me | | | | |

| What I need from them | | | | |

| Last time I expressed a genuine need | | | | |

| One thing I want to change | | | | |

Section B: Communication Style Assessment

Rate yourself honestly from 1 (never) to 5 (frequently):

Command-and-Control Tendencies

- I give direction without explanation: ____
- I expect compliance rather than discussion: ____

- I cut off conversation when I've made up my mind: ____
- I deliver feedback bluntly without relational context: ____

Hyper-Independence Tendencies

- I refuse help even when I need it: ____
- I handle problems alone without telling people I'm struggling: ____
- I make decisions that affect others without consulting them: ____
- I feel resentful when people don't step up — even though I didn't ask: ____

Emotional Availability

- I express what I'm actually feeling in close relationships: ____
- I ask for what I need directly: ____
- I listen without preparing my response while they're still talking: ____
- I acknowledge when a conversation is emotionally hard for me: ____

Scoring:

- Command-and-Control: ____/20 (higher = more military-default communication)
 - Hyper-Independence: ____/20 (higher = more walls up)
 - Emotional Availability: ____/20 (higher = more accessible)
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Section C: Needs Statements Worksheet

Write one direct needs statement for three key relationships using this format:

"When [specific situation], I need [specific ask], because [honest reason]."

Relationship 1:

When: _____

I need: _____

Because: _____

Relationship 2:

When: _____

I need: _____

Because: _____

Relationship 3:

When: _____

I need: _____

Because: _____

Section D: Boundary Setting Template

Use this framework to articulate and communicate a boundary in a key relationship:

The behavior I need to change:

The specific, observable thing that's happening:

The honest impact on me:

The specific ask:

What I will do if the boundary isn't respected:

How I will communicate this:

■ In person, planned conversation

■ Written first, then in person

■ Other: _____

Section E: 90-Day Communication Goals

| Goal | Relationship | Specific Behavior | Success Indicator | Accountability |

|---|---|---|---|---|

| 1 | | | | |

| 2 | | | | |

| 3 | | | | |

Weekly Check-in Questions:

- Did I do what I committed to this week?

- What resistance came up?
 - What worked better than expected?
 - What do I need to adjust?
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MISSION REBUILD™ | Module 06 Complete

Next: Module 07 — Physical Health and Performance